

Building Bilingual Education in Cape Verde: A Practical Guide



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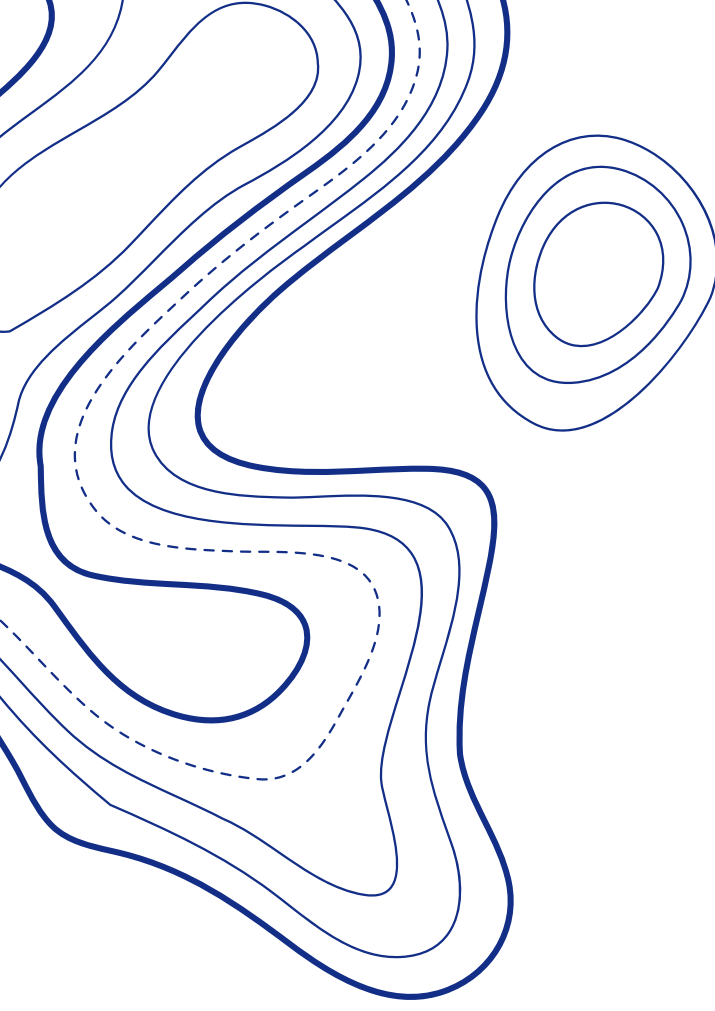
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Purpose of this Resource

This resource is designed to support bilingual education in Cape Verde by sharing lessons and effective practices from the Si ka fila tudu, ta fila un ponta project (2013–2019). It includes insights from teachers, activists, and parents on promoting bilingualism in Cape Verdean Creole and Portuguese. The resource offers strategies for creating an inclusive, fair learning environment that reflects Cape Verde's language and culture. While focused on Cape Verde, these ideas can help in other multilingual contexts, too.

Background

This resource is based on a British Academy project titled Monolingual Schools in Multilingual Societies: Rethinking Language and Education in Cape Verde. The project explores the challenges and benefits of bilingual education in Cape Verde, where Portuguese is the main language used in schools, despite Cape Verdean Creole (Kriolu) being the first language for nearly everyone. The project contributes to recent shifts toward more inclusive education models that embrace local cultures, values, and languages (Djité, 2008; Chimbutane, 2011, 2018; García & Kleifgen, 2010). By responding to calls for education based on students' first language (L1), the project examines how including local languages in schools can improve learning outcomes and promote social equity.

Cape Verde's Journey Toward Bilingualism





As Cape Verdean linguist Manuel Veiga (2004) describes, bilingualism in Cape Verde is still “under construction”. There are differences in status, prestige, and usage of the country’s two languages, Portuguese and Cape Verdean Creole, which need to be addressed to create balanced bilingualism.

Bilingualism in Cape Verde tends to be individual, with people usually learning Portuguese formally in school after already knowing Cape Verdean Creole as their first language (Duarte, 1998). Schools are the main way people learn Portuguese, which has led to a form of bilingualism driven by the education system. However, because schools mostly use Portuguese, there’s little room for students to develop equal skills in both languages.

Without support for literacy in both languages (biliteracy), many Cape Verdeans have only a limited ability to use Portuguese. They can understand Portuguese but may not feel confident speaking or writing in it. Studies in other African countries show that teaching in the mother tongue can lead to better grades in all subjects and reduce the risk of students repeating grades, failing, or dropping out (Benson, 2014, 2021). Most Cape Verdeans are much more comfortable in Cape Verdean Creole, making it difficult to use Portuguese effectively in all contexts.

The Importance of Mother Tongue Education

UNESCO has recommended using the mother tongue in education since 1953 as a foundation for true bilingualism. Studies show that learning in a student's first language builds confidence, helps them participate more in class, and improves self-esteem (Ouane & Glanz, 2010; UNESCO, 2016). Researchers have long argued for multilingual education that values the first language (see, e.g., Bamgbose, 2000; Ouane & Glanz, 2010). Removing language hierarchies in the classroom can also create new, inclusive ways of teaching (Kerfoot & Bello-Nonjengele, 2016).

The bilingual programme *Si ka fila tudu, ta fila un ponta* (If Everything Is Not Achieved, at Least Something Is), run in Cape Verde from 2013 to 2019, had a big impact by highlighting the value of teaching in students' first language and promoting bilingualism. The lessons from this programme provide insights into effective strategies for encouraging bilingualism in Cape Verdean schools.

The following sections will look at the key factors that made the programme successful and specific practices that helped support Cape Verdean Creole in schools.





What Worked Well in the Bilingual Programme and Why

The bilingual programme was successful because it focused on treating the mother tongue, Cape Verdean Creole, with the same respect as Portuguese. The first step was training teachers to feel confident in using Cape Verdean Creole both as a subject and as the main language for teaching other subjects, like Maths and Science.

The programme used a model called Total Bilingualism, or Dual Language Education. This meant that both Cape Verdean Creole and Portuguese were used equally in the classroom. Both languages were treated as subjects and as languages for teaching other subjects, helping students learn to read and write in both languages at the same time.

In this model, both languages were used 50% of the time to make sure students developed strong skills in both. This balance helped students become fluent in speaking, reading, and writing in both Cape Verdean Creole and Portuguese, leading to high achievement in school subjects. The programme also helped students build positive attitudes, learn about citizenship, and develop critical thinking skills. These improvements were clear in how well the students performed during the programme.

"My daughter was always eager to do her homework. She was always motivated to show the new things she learned in Creole. She learned to read and write faster, in both Portuguese and Creole at the same time. At home, she teaches us how to write in Creole because no one at home knows how to. She teaches and corrects in both languages. Her older brother only started reading in the 2nd grade, but she could already read and write in Portuguese and Creole by the 1st grade."

Parent





"Creole... gained a status it previously didn't have in people's eyes. Both students felt more at ease because they could speak their mother tongue, and so did the teacher."

Researcher

"(The students are) more spontaneous and motivated in class. They show a better command of Portuguese and achieve better results in other subjects. They are very creative—using the same picture, they write one story in Portuguese and a completely different one in Creole. The two texts are not translations of each other; they are two distinct stories."

Teacher

"...there were two group trials here on the island of Santiago, with the idea of expanding to other islands and demonstrating, through experimentation, the benefits of bilingual education in Cape Verdean Creole. From what I saw—because I attended two sessions with groups of students who were part of this experiment—I could see that the students spoke Cape Verdean Creole well, wrote well, and spoke and wrote Portuguese well, in fact, better than those who had only studied in Portuguese..."

Literary Writer



Teacher Training is Essential

It is not enough for a teacher to be a native speaker of Cape Verdean Creole to teach it effectively. Just like Portuguese or other subjects, teaching Cape Verdean Creole requires specific knowledge about the language and how to teach it well. If teachers don't already have a background in Cape Verdean Creole, they should receive additional training.

In this programme, teachers learned about the Cape Verdean Creole alphabet, writing, and grammar. They were also trained in teaching methods for the mother tongue, bilingualism and how people learn a second language, and how to create teaching materials for Cape Verdean Creole.

The Ministry of Education's involvement was critical for the programme's success. By providing regular school visits, classroom observations, and feedback, the Ministry validated the programme and showed teachers that their efforts were valued. This support encouraged teachers and students to work with focus and dedication, which was evident in the students' strong progress. Due to this success, the programme was expanded to more schools after the first year.





Family Involvement Matters



"A mother who is a fish seller and illiterate had never sat on a school bench before, and she was surprised when I invited her to come to the classroom to talk about her work selling fish. She said she never thought she had anything to teach that could be of interest in school. I used what she shared in class, and we did a Maths lesson with problems about how many fish you can buy with a certain amount of money, giving change, etc. She was very happy, and the children also learned that everyone has something they can teach others."

Teacher



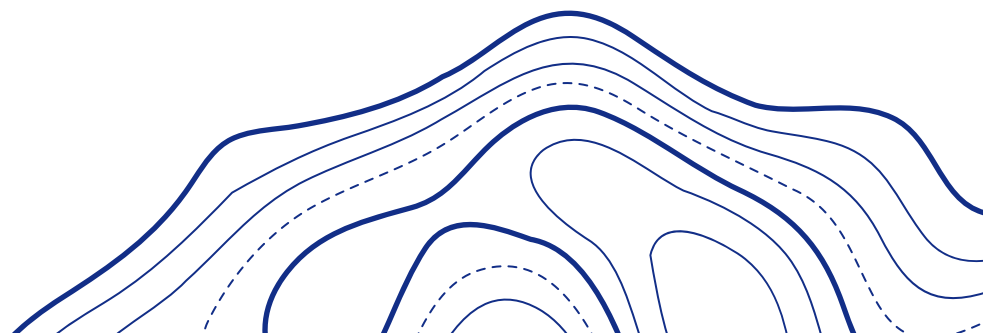


Family support is key to students' academic success. From the beginning, parents were invited to sessions where they could learn about bilingual education, understand its benefits, and ask questions.

Throughout the programme, parents met with teachers, the project leader, and Ministry representatives to discuss their children's progress and the impact of using Cape Verdean Creole in school on family life. This involvement helped parents understand and support their children's learning. Families also took part in classroom activities by sharing their stories and experiences, feeling respected and included as their contributions were woven into school lessons.

"I don't know Portuguese, I studied very little and have forgotten it, but I helped with some Creole homework. Sometimes I needed to tell a story or explain a word, or say how things were in the past, and I can help with that. Now I enjoy going to school. In the meetings, they speak Creole, and I understand."

Parent



The Cape Verdean Language Programme

The Cape Verdean Language Programme was created from the ground up to fit into the existing curriculum, which was only in Portuguese. The programme focused on Cape Verdean Creole as a subject, meaning it only added content specific to learning Cape Verdean Creole itself. When Cape Verdean Creole was used to teach other subjects, like Maths or Science, the same official curriculum content was followed, ensuring that all material was covered, regardless of the language used.

Results showed that students in bilingual classes developed strong language skills and awareness. They could easily distinguish between Portuguese and Cape Verdean Creole because they learned both languages formally, with attention to their differences, which helped avoid mixing them up. These students became fluent in speaking and writing both languages, using them confidently in various situations without hesitation or bias. They expressed themselves clearly and thoughtfully, adapting their language to fit different audiences. Their performance in Portuguese even surpassed that of students in Portuguese-only classes.





What is Needed for Future Bilingual Programmes?





To set up successful bilingual programmes, a commitment from the education authority and funding are essential. Investment is needed to train teachers, create a bilingual curriculum, and develop materials for teaching both Cape Verdean Creole and Portuguese. A team of experts is also critical to lead and oversee the programme.

Key steps include:

- Allocating a dedicated budget for designing and implementing the bilingual programme.
- Training for teachers.
- Choosing a bilingual education model that fits the local, Cape Verdean context.
- Forming a team of experts to create both the bilingual education curriculum and a Cape Verdean Creole language curriculum.
- Establishing a team to develop teaching materials.

What Should a Future Bilingual Programme in Cape Verde Include?



“What I see is that there is always a barrier in the early years, especially on the more remote islands or in schools serving less affluent families. There is a huge barrier for students when Portuguese is spoken, but if Creole, the Cape Verdean language, is spoken, the children immediately open up, become uninhibited, speak naturally. I think that education in Cape Verde should begin precisely with Cape Verdean Creole because it is the mother tongue, the language of affection, the language in which people feel much more comfortable. The children open up with much more joy to learn, so that’s why I say that Cape Verdean Creole should be the starting point for everything. From Cape Verdean Creole, people could go on to learn Portuguese and other languages, and this should start from an early age.”

Teacher



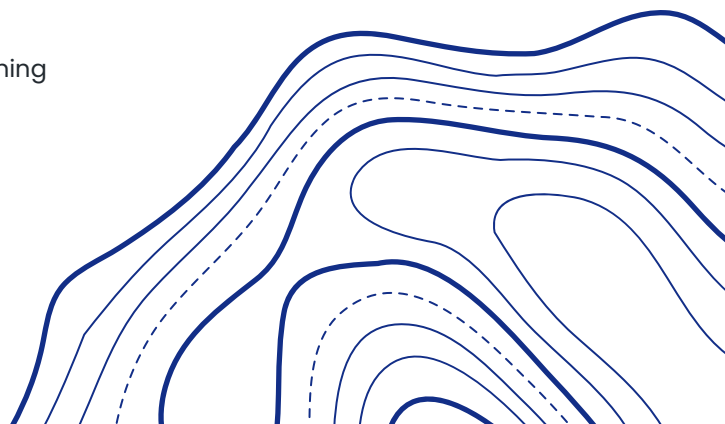
A future bilingual programme in Cape Verde should be widely available to all children and adapted to fit the local context.

The chosen bilingual model should focus on building strong bilingual skills, with the goal of students becoming literate in both languages. Ideally, formal teaching of both the mother tongue (Cape Verdean Creole) and the second language (Portuguese) should begin as early as preschool, using age-appropriate teaching methods.

The programme should include ongoing supervision and evaluation to monitor both teaching quality and student progress. Schools should also clearly define who communicates in each language, ensuring effective use of both languages in the learning environment.

"A child learns languages if they have a fundamental foundation, which is their mother tongue, allowing them to go on to develop other languages—second, third, fourth, fifth, etc..."

Teacher



What Resources and Training Do Teachers Need for a Bilingual Programme?

For a successful bilingual programme, comprehensive teacher training is essential. This involves large-scale training for both teachers who specialize in the Cape Verdean language and those who will use the language to teach other subjects.

Teachers should receive training in these key areas:

- Teaching Methods for the Mother Tongue
- Teaching Methods for a Second Language
- Bilingual Education Models
- The Cape Verdean Language Alphabet and Writing
- Cape Verdean Language Grammar
- Writing Skills in Cape Verdean Language
- Dialectal Varieties of Cape Verdean Creole
- Cape Verdean Literature and Literature in the Cape Verdean Language
- Creating Teaching Materials in Cape Verdean Language
- Producing Bilingual Teaching Resources
- Understanding Areas Prone to Language Interference between Portuguese and Cape Verdean Creole

"There should be a textbook, continuous teacher training, especially in grammar... At first, I was afraid, but now I'm not. I've learned a lot, a lot about the Cape Verdean language that... I had no idea even existed. So much, for example, when it comes to writing in Cape Verdean Creole—there's a lot that I thought I knew, but I didn't. I've learned a great deal, and now I write in Cape Verdean Creole with much more confidence."

Teacher of Cape Verdean Creole in 10th Grade



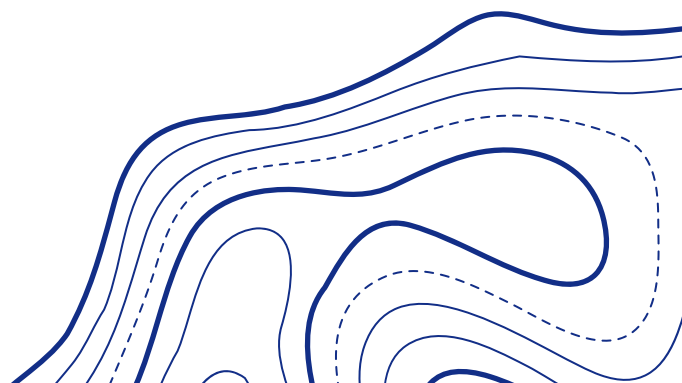


Textbooks are crucial for supporting both teachers and students. In addition to a Cape Verdean language textbook designed to match the curriculum, methodology, and teaching strategies, schools should also provide a resource centre. This centre should offer materials for bilingual education, such as dictionaries, grammar books, Cape Verdean Creole literature, bilingual textbooks for different subjects, and other resources on the Cape Verdean language.

The library should also have books in both Cape Verdean Creole and Portuguese, tailored to the students' age group, to encourage reading and language development in both languages.

"Increasing the availability of these materials and creating new materials... when we start working and producing Cape Verdean language textbooks that aren't just copies of existing Portuguese textbooks."

Researcher



Can Regional Variation in Cape Verde be an Obstacle to Using the Mother Tongue in Education?



"Variants have always existed and will always continue to exist in Cape Verde, and I am not at all against them; on the contrary, it's about diversity, it's about diversity. After all, it's the diversity of the people themselves that have these variants—it's a richness."

Literary Writer





The different dialects of Cape Verdean Creole are not an obstacle to using the mother tongue in schools. All languages have regional variations, and this doesn't stop the choice of a standard version, even though a standard for Creole has not yet been fully established.

According to Veiga (1995), while Cape Verdean Creole shows some differences in its surface features across dialects, at a deeper level, it is one unified language. This shared structure allows speakers of different dialects to understand each other quite well.

Veiga also suggests that Cape Verdean Creole could be represented by two main versions: the Sotavento variety, based on the Santiago dialect, and the Barlavento variety, based on the São Vicente dialect. These two versions would group similar dialects from each region, making it easier to use Creole in education.

"A standard does not invalidate the continuation of variants; variants, of course—if it's good for Portugal, it can't be bad for Cape Verde; if it's good for France, it can't be bad just for Cape Verde..."

Activist

"This is a false issue because in France, not all French people speak French with the same accent, nor do people in Portugal speak Portuguese in the same way. So, this is a false issue..."

Activist

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